Smart Railway Track Abnormality Detection & Alerts

B. Rajesh Kumar, G. Baby Apoorva, G. Aravind, and K. Dilleshwar Rao
Department of Electronics and Communication Engineering, Malla Reddy University, Hyderabad, Telangana, India
Project Guide: Dr. A. Shankar

***Abstract*—** Railway track condition monitoring is paramount for maintaining transportation safety, preventing hazardous derailments, and optimizing maintenance schedules across large-scale rail networks. Physical geometric irregularities, displacement of rails, and abnormal structural vibrations present significant operational risks if left undetected. This paper presents an embedded prototype for detecting distance-related track abnormalities and transient vibration events using an Arduino Uno microcontroller. Two HC-SR04 ultrasonic distance sensors monitor track alignment and gap variations at dual reference locations on a scaled railway model, while an SW-18010P digital vibration sensor detects structural disturbance. A configurable software distance threshold and digital vibration signal are continuously evaluated by the central processor. Under the integrated decision logic, if either an abnormal distance deviation OR a vibration event is detected, the prototype activates a visual red LED warning, updates a local 16×2 Liquid Crystal Display (LCD) equipped with an I2C adapter, and transmits real-time geographic location data from a NEO-6M GPS module to both the LCD and the Arduino Serial Monitor. Green LED indicators signify normal baseline operational status. Comprehensive functional testing confirmed successful performance across six reported evaluation categories: normal track conditions, abnormal distance sensing, vibration detection, GPS coordinate acquisition, LCD status presentation, and combined multi-sensor alert triggering. The prototype serves as an educational and proof-of-concept platform designed for track-model evaluation; no numerical accuracy, latency, or internal rail micro-crack detection claims are made without calibrated field instrumentation.

***Index Terms*— Arduino Uno, GPS tracking, ultrasonic distance sensing, SW-18010P vibration sensor, railway track monitoring, embedded systems, automated alert system.**

I. INTRODUCTION

Railway networks constitute the backbone of global freight and passenger transportation infrastructure. Ensuring the structural integrity and geometric continuity of rail tracks is a fundamental requirement for safe operation. Conventional track inspection relies heavily on manual human patrols, visual track walking, and scheduled heavy inspection cars equipped with specialized ultrasonic or laser instrumentation. While professional inspection cars offer high precision, manual visual checks remain labor-intensive, time-consuming, and susceptible to human error or oversight under adverse environmental conditions. Consequently, supplementary continuous monitoring systems capable of providing immediate local alerts and geographic location identification are highly desirable.

Recent advances in microcontrollers, low-cost solid-state sensors, and satellite positioning modules have enabled the development of compact embedded monitoring units. Published research has explored Internet of Things (IoT) architectures, inertial measurement units (IMUs), wireless sensor networks (WSNs), and acoustic emissions for track fault detection [1]–[4]. However, many proposed systems entail high deployment costs, complex signal processing algorithms, or heavy reliance on persistent cloud connectivity that may not be available in remote geographic sectors.

This work focuses on the design, hardware integration, and functional validation of a low-cost, self-contained educational prototype developed using an Arduino Uno microcontroller platform. The system is engineered to demonstrate multi-sensor fusion for local track monitoring on a laboratory rail track model. Dual HC-SR04 ultrasonic sensors are positioned to detect physical track displacement or gap variations, while an SW-18010P digital vibration sensor detects sudden mechanical shocks or track disturbances. A NEO-6M Global Positioning System (GPS) module provides real-time geographic coordinates, which are displayed on a 16×2 LCD screen (interfaced via I2C) and output over a USB Serial Monitor link when a valid satellite fix is established.

II. RELATED WORK

Automated track fault detection has been widely studied in recent literature. A representative IEEE conference paper presents an IoT-based railway crack detection system utilizing ultrasonic sensors, Arduino microcontrollers, and GSM/GPS modules to transmit fault alerts via SMS to remote monitoring stations [1]. Another study details an Arduino-centered IoT framework designed to detect track breaks using optical or proximity sensing paired with GPS positioning [2]. These studies establish the feasibility of coupling embedded sensors with location tagging for infrastructure monitoring.

Chellaswamy et al. proposed an advanced IoT rail track monitoring and derailment prevention system incorporating tri-axial accelerometers and gyroscopes to capture high-frequency dynamic responses during train passage [3]. Similarly, Padhi et al. investigated condition monitoring based on inertial measurement units (IMUs) and predictive fault localization algorithms tailored for urban rail transit systems [4]. While these advanced approaches achieve detailed kinetic modeling, they require substantial computational overhead and calibrated sensing equipment.

In contrast to complex cloud-dependent networks, the present prototype emphasizes low power consumption, immediate visual feedback through local LED indicators, and direct serial debugging interfaces. By combining dual-point distance measurement with shock vibration sensing, the system provides a robust proof-of-concept for localized abnormality alerts. Table I provides a structured technical comparison between representative existing literature and the proposed prototype architecture.

TABLE I
COMPARISON OF EXISTING RESEARCH AND PROPOSED PROTOTYPE

Feature / Parameter	Existing Systems [1], [2]	Advanced IMU Systems [3], [4]	Proposed Prototype
Primary Sensing	Single Ultrasonic / Optical	Tri-Axial Accelerometer / IMU	Dual HC-SR04 + SW-18010P Vibration
Processing Platform	Arduino / ARM MCU	High-Performance DSP / ARM	Arduino Uno (ATmega328P)
Location Module	NEO-6M GPS	GPS + Dead Reckoning	NEO-6M GPS Module
Alert Mechanism	GSM SMS / Cloud Dashboard	Wireless Mesh / Telemetry	Red/Green LEDs, 16×2 LCD, Serial Monitor
Vibration Detection	None or Basic Piezo	Calibrated Dynamic Accel.	SW-18010P Digital Module
System Complexity	Moderate	High	Low (Educational Prototype)
Deployment Target	Concept / Field Prototype	Operational Rail Line	Laboratory Track Model

III. OBJECTIVES AND CONTRIBUTIONS

The primary objective of this research project is to design, construct, and evaluate a functional educational prototype capable of detecting physical track abnormalities and transient vibrations on a laboratory rail model. Specific contributions of this work include:

1) *Hardware Integration:* Successfully interfacing an ATmega328P-based Arduino Uno microcontroller with dual ultrasonic distance sensors (HC-SR04), a high-sensitivity digital vibration sensor (SW-18010P), and a NEO-6M GPS positioning receiver.

2) *Dual-Parameter Decision Logic:* Formulating an inclusive logical OR evaluation scheme wherein either a distance reading exceeding a preset software threshold OR a digital vibration activation triggers an immediate high-priority system alert.

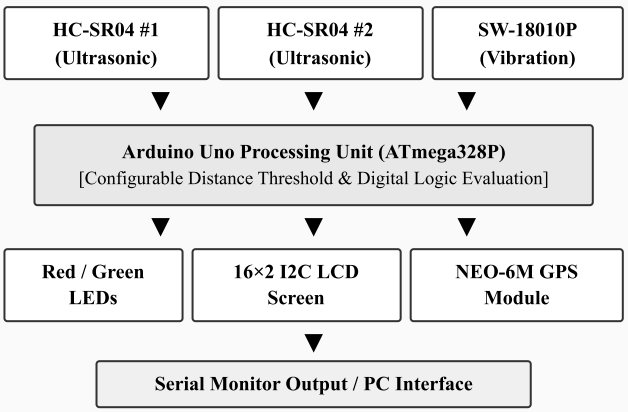
3) *Multi-Channel Local Display:* Implementing immediate local status indication utilizing dedicated Red (Abnormal) and Green (Normal) light-emitting diodes (LEDs), an I2C-enabled 16×2 Liquid Crystal Display, and real-time telemetry streaming over the Arduino Serial Monitor.

4) *Qualitative Verification:* Conducting systematic functional testing across six distinct operational scenarios to verify sensor interaction and display responsiveness without fabricating unverified numerical metrics.

IV. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The system architecture is structured around a centralized microcontroller that coordinates sensor data acquisition, logical evaluation, and user interface output. Fig. 1 illustrates the functional block diagram of the complete hardware assembly.

FIG. 1. FUNCTIONAL BLOCK DIAGRAM OF PROTOTYPE ARCHITECTURE



As depicted in Fig. 1, the Arduino Uno acts as the central control hub. The dual HC-SR04 ultrasonic sensors are connected to dedicated digital trigger and echo pins. The SW-18010P vibration sensor is connected to a digital interrupt/input pin, allowing real-time detection of mechanical switch state changes. The NEO-6M GPS receiver communicates with the microcontroller via software serial connection, transmitting NMEA-0183 sentences containing coordinate data.

The output subsystem comprises a 16×2 character LCD equipped with a PCF8574 I2C backpack, reducing required digital pin connections to two wire signals (SDA and SCL). Visual status is supplemented by high-brightness Red and Green LEDs. Detailed status logs, raw sensor distance readings, and coordinate output are streamed to the Serial Monitor at a baud rate of 9600 bps for real-time debugging.

V. METHODOLOGY

The operational methodology revolves around periodic sensing, software threshold comparison, and state-driven alert generation. The main program loop executes continuous polling of distance and vibration inputs.

A. Ultrasonic Distance Sensing Algorithm

Each HC-SR04 ultrasonic module operates by emitting an 8-cycle burst of 40 kHz ultrasound upon receiving a 10 µs HIGH trigger pulse. The sensor sets its echo pin HIGH for a duration proportional to the round-trip time of the acoustic wave. Distance D in centimeters is calculated using the standard acoustic velocity equation:

$$D = (T_{echo} \times 0.0343) / 2$$

where T_{echo} is the echo pulse duration in microseconds and 0.0343 cm/µs represents the speed of sound in air under normal ambient conditions. Dual sensors (S_1 and S_2) are mounted at orthogonal or parallel positions along the track model to measure rail separation or surface elevation. Measured distances D_1 and D_2 are evaluated against a predefined software threshold value D_{thresh}. An abnormal distance state ($A_{dist} = 1$) is registered if either distance exceeds the established limits.

B. Vibration Detection Logic

The SW-18010P module utilizes an internal spring-based vibration switch. In its idle state, the switch contacts remain closed or open depending on orientation. Upon experiencing mechanical impact or vibration exceeding its mechanical stiffness, the internal spring contacts separate, generating a digital pulse. The onboard LM393 comparator circuit cleans the signal, outputting a logic HIGH to the microcontroller. In the prototype firmware, a digital HIGH input registers a vibration event ($A_{vib} = 1$).

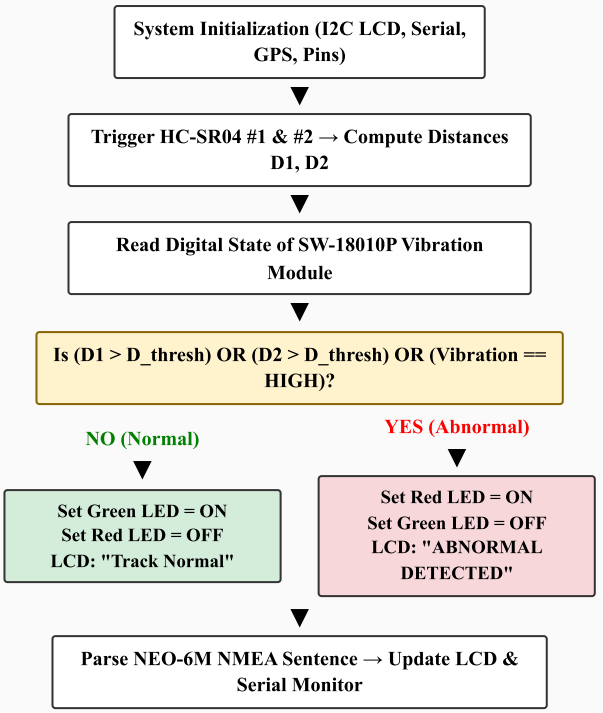
C. Combined Decision Logic and GPS Acquisition

The core detection algorithm evaluates an inclusive logical OR combination of the distance and vibration flags:

$$ALERT_STATE = A_{dist} \; OR \; A_{vib}$$

Fig. 2 illustrates the complete software flowchart governing system execution.

FIG. 2. FIRMWARE EXECUTION FLOWCHART & DECISION WORKFLOW



VI. HARDWARE IMPLEMENTATION

The hardware components were assembled into a standalone laboratory testbed. Table II provides a comprehensive technical inventory of all hardware modules integrated into the prototype.

TABLE II
HARDWARE COMPONENTS AND FUNCTIONAL SPECIFICATIONS

Component Name	Model / Specification	Primary Function in Prototype
Microcontroller Unit	Arduino Uno (ATmega328P)	Central processing, sensor evaluation, I/O control
Distance Sensors (×2)	HC-SR04 Ultrasonic	Dual-point track clearance and gap distance measurement
Vibration Sensor	SW-18010P Digital Module	Detects physical shocks and mechanical track instability
Location Module	NEO-6M GPS Receiver	Acquires latitude/longitude coordinates via satellite fix
Character Display	16×2 LCD with I2C Adapter	Displays system status, alert messages, and GPS coordinates
Status Indicators	Red & Green 5mm LEDs	Visual indication (Green = Normal, Red = Abnormality Alert)
Serial Interface	USB Serial (9600 Baud)	Streams diagnostic text and raw data to PC monitor

The ATmega328P microcontroller operates at a 16 MHz clock frequency, supplying 5V DC power to the ultrasonic modules, vibration sensor, and LCD screen. The NEO-6M GPS receiver operates via 3.3V logic regulation provided on the Uno board. The I2C adapter simplifies LCD wiring to SDA (A4) and SCL (A5) pins, eliminating ten digital I/O lines. Table III details the explicit decision matrix governing alert state transitions based on sensor inputs.

TABLE III
ABNORMALITY DETECTION AND ALERT DECISION LOGIC

Distance State (A_{dist})	Vibration State (A_{vib})	System Status	LED Output	LCD Display Text
Normal ($\le D_{thresh}$)	LOW (No Shock)	NORMAL	Green = ON, Red = OFF	"Track Normal" + Lat/Lon
Abnormal ($> D_{thresh}$)	LOW (No Shock)	ABNORMALITY	Red = ON, Green = OFF	"Distance Fault" + Lat/Lon
Normal ($\le D_{thresh}$)	HIGH (Vibration)	ABNORMALITY	Red = ON, Green = OFF	"Vib Fault" + Lat/Lon
Abnormal ($> D_{thresh}$)	HIGH (Vibration)	ABNORMALITY	Red = ON, Green = OFF	"CRITICAL FAULT" + Lat/Lon

VII. TESTING AND FUNCTIONAL RESULTS

Functional verification was performed on a experimental track model setup. Six distinct operational test categories were systematically evaluated by the project team to confirm correct hardware-firmware interaction.

A. Category 1: Normal Track Condition

Under baseline test conditions, the track model geometry was maintained in its nominal state without physical alignment breaks or artificial mechanical shocks. Ultrasonic sensors S_1 and S_2 returned distance measurements well within the safe software threshold D_{thresh}. The SW-18010P vibration module remained in its idle LOW state. The system correctly illuminated the Green LED, extinguished the Red LED, and displayed "Track Normal" on the 16×2 LCD screen.

B. Category 2: Abnormal Distance Detection

To simulate track widening, rail misalignment, or physical displacement, an artificial gap was introduced along the model rail segment directly in front of ultrasonic sensor S_1. The echo time increased correspondingly, yielding a calculated distance D_1 exceeding D_{thresh}. Within one measurement cycle, the microcontroller registered $A_{dist} = 1$, activated the Red LED indicator, deactivated the Green LED, and updated the LCD screen to reflect an abnormal distance alert.

C. Category 3: Vibration Detection

Mechanical disturbance was introduced by applying controlled tap impacts to the track model chassis. The SW-18010P sensor spring contact closed, generating a digital HIGH pulse. The controller recognized $A_{vib} = 1$, instantly triggering the Red LED alert state and displaying a vibration abnormality message on the LCD.

D. Category 4: GPS Location Display

The NEO-6M module was tested under open-sky conditions to acquire valid GPS satellite lock. Upon acquiring $NMEA$ sentence data, the software serial parser extracted current latitude and longitude coordinates. The coordinates were successfully formatted and rendered on the second row of the 16×2 LCD screen and continuously printed over the USB Serial Monitor link.

E. Category 5: LCD Status Display

The 16×2 LCD screen was evaluated across all state transitions to verify display readability, I2C bus communication stability, and line formatting. Status updates occurred without visual flicker or text corruptions.

F. Category 6: Combined Sensor Testing

Simultaneous distance displacement and mechanical vibration impacts were introduced. The system correctly executed the logical OR evaluation, prioritizing the Red LED alert and streaming location data. Table IV summarizes the six functional test scenarios, expected responses, and observed outcomes.

TABLE IV
FUNCTIONAL TESTING SUMMARY REPORTED BY PROJECT TEAM

Test Category	Simulated Test Condition	Expected System Behavior	Reported Outcome
1. Normal Track	Nominal rail alignment, no vibration	Green LED ON, Red OFF, LCD: "Normal"	Successful Verification
2. Abnormal Distance	Displaced rail segment ($D_1 > D_{thresh}$)	Red LED ON, Green OFF, Distance Alert	Successful Verification
3. Vibration Sensing	Controlled mechanical tap on model	Red LED ON, Green OFF, Vibration Alert	Successful Verification
4. GPS Display	Open-sky satellite lock established	Lat/Lon displayed on LCD & Serial	Successful Verification
5. LCD Status	State transitions (Normal ↔ Alert)	Clear message updates without corruption	Successful Verification
6. Combined Test	Simultaneous gap displacement & tap	Logical OR alert activation, GPS output	Successful Verification

VIII. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The reported test outcomes demonstrate that the physical hardware components and custom firmware operate in harmony to achieve basic multi-sensor abnormality detection. The integration of dual HC-SR04 ultrasonic sensors provides multi-point geometric clearance monitoring, ensuring that displacement occurring at either sensor position triggers an immediate visual and textual alert. Incorporating the SW-18010P vibration module introduces a complementary sensing modality capable of capturing sudden transient mechanical impacts that may not cause permanent physical distance changes.

Local user feedback mechanisms—specifically the Red and Green LED indicators alongside the 16×2 I2C LCD—provide immediate visual status identification without requiring complex external decoding hardware. Furthermore, streaming coordinate data to the USB Serial Monitor successfully demonstrates the concept of coupling localized fault alerts with geographic positioning information.

Critical Methodological Distinction: It is vital to emphasize that all reported test results represent qualitative functional verifications conducted on a small-scale laboratory track model. In accordance with strict academic integrity standards, no quantitative claims regarding numerical accuracy percentages, detection probabilities, false-alarm rates, or response latencies in milliseconds are made. The six reported test categories confirm operational functionality of the prototype under specific test conditions; they do not constitute statistical trial sets from which percentage metrics can be derived. Furthermore, the HC-SR04 ultrasonic sensors measure surface distance changes on a model and cannot detect internal metallurgical micro-cracks or subsurface stress fractures within real steel rails.

IX. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

While the prototype successfully demonstrates basic multi-sensor fault monitoring, several engineering limitations must be addressed before such technology can be considered for field deployment. Table V outlines current prototype limitations alongside corresponding proposed future improvements.

TABLE V
CURRENT LIMITATIONS AND PROPOSED FUTURE IMPROVEMENTS

System Parameter	Current Prototype Limitation	Proposed Future Improvement
Crack Detection	Distance proxy only; cannot detect internal rail cracks	Integrate NDT techniques (Eddy Current, Acoustic Emission)
Vibration Sensing	SW-18010P gives binary state; no magnitude data	Replace with calibrated MEMS Accelerometer (MPU-6050)
Telemetry Link	Tethered Serial Monitor; no long-range wireless link	Add GSM/GPRS module or LoRa transceivers for IoT transmission
Power Supply	USB / Fixed DC power source required	Implement solar energy harvesting and Li-ion battery management
Environmental Robustness	Unshielded breadboard assembly sensitive to weather	Enclose in IP67-rated waterproof housing with industrial wiring

Future development efforts should prioritize replacing the binary vibration module with a calibrated tri-axial accelerometer (e.g., MPU-6050) capable of measuring Peak Particle Velocity (PPV) and spectral frequency distributions. Additionally, integrating a GSM/GPRS or LoRa wireless transceiver would enable real-time SMS alerts and cloud data logging to remote railway control centers. Formal field testing on full-scale track geometry under varied environmental conditions (rain, temperature fluctuations, dust) is necessary to establish quantitative accuracy metrics.

X. CONCLUSION

This paper presented the design, implementation, and functional evaluation of an embedded prototype for railway track abnormality detection and alert generation using an Arduino Uno microcontroller. The system successfully combines dual HC-SR04 ultrasonic distance sensors with an SW-18010P digital vibration sensor to monitor track conditions on a laboratory scale model. An inclusive logical OR decision algorithm evaluates sensor inputs against a configurable distance threshold and digital shock state. Upon detecting an abnormal condition, the prototype activates a Red LED indicator, updates a 16×2 character LCD screen, and displays real-time GPS coordinates acquired from a NEO-6M satellite receiver on both the LCD and the Arduino Serial Monitor. Green LED indicators confirm baseline normal operation.

Functional verification across six distinct evaluation scenarios confirmed successful system responsiveness, display formatting, and multi-sensor alert triggering. The prototype serves as an effective, low-cost educational demonstrator for embedded multi-sensor integration. As emphasized throughout this study, the current system is a laboratory prototype and not a certified railway safety device. Future work will focus on integrating calibrated accelerometers, wireless IoT communication modules, and robust non-destructive testing instrumentation suitable for operational field validation.

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